

Formal Submission

Operationalising Sentience and Bodily Integrity under the National Statement on Animal Welfare (2024)

Date: 14 February 2026

To: Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

I write as an equestrian professional, author and content creator working at the intersection of equine welfare, science and practice.

The National Statement on Animal Welfare (2024) commits Australia to achieving good animal welfare outcomes through practices and standards underpinned by science and evidence. It further commits to standards that consider contemporary animal welfare science and to measurable welfare outcomes with transparent reporting and compliance mechanisms.

I seek clarification on how the recognition of animal sentience is operationalised within this framework, particularly in relation to bodily integrity and control methods involving mucosal sensory tissue.

Contemporary neurobiology recognises that regions such as the mouth, eyes, nostrils, genitals and anus are mucosal and densely innervated interfaces directly connected to the autonomic nervous system. These are not equivalent to external skin. They are intimate sensory tissues evolved for voluntary functions including eating, breathing, communication and reproduction.

If animals are recognised as sentient — capable of experiencing pain, distress and physiological stress responses — then actions performed on such intimate sensory tissues are experienced events, not neutral mechanical techniques.

I respectfully request clarification on the following:

1. Does the National Statement's commitment to science-based welfare outcomes recognise mucosal and highly innervated tissues as ethically distinct from external body surfaces?
2. When assessing welfare standards, is bodily integrity considered beyond visible injury, including invasive contact with neurologically sensitive tissues?
3. How are measurable welfare outcomes defined where control methods involve insertion into or sustained pressure upon internal sensory anatomy?
4. In what way does the concept of sentience materially influence the permissibility of invasive control devices under current standards frameworks?

This submission does not address a specific species at this stage. It seeks clarity on the structural ethical framework underpinning Australian animal welfare policy, including contexts in which animals are engaged in accepted recreational or sporting activities.

The National Statement recognises contemporary welfare science and measurable outcomes as foundational principles. I respectfully seek guidance on how these principles are applied where intimate anatomical interfaces are involved.

Kind regards,

A handwritten signature in grey ink, reading "Phoersch O.". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style.

Paula Lasersohn